Generating a Story Idea

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Introduction

An idea for a story is the same as air to one's lungs. You need air to survive, and a story needs an idea to even come into existence.

An idea for a story is what creates the world that your characters live and breathe in. It sets the stage for the plot to flow and for the characters to grow. It even helps to create the foundations of the world itself, its laws, its physics, its cultures, its entire being.

You'll Need…

- Any kind of tool that allows you to write and organize your ideas. It could be something like a pen and paper, a notepad, or a whiteboard. It could also be computerized; Microsoft Word or Google Docs will work too.

Getting Started

Step 1: Choose a Genre

This can be something like sci-fi, historical fiction, drama, fantasy, noir, stone-age, etc. It can also be a combination, too.

Step 2: Make a Protagonist

Think of someone that the story will revolve around. You'll also want to look at aspects of the character, too, such as their age, role, or unique traits that separate them from others.

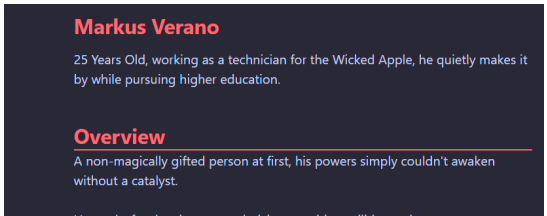

Figure 1. A screenshot from Obsidian.md, depicting a protagonist from the book I'm working on. Source: Brian Nguyen

Step 3: Choose a Setting

A setting is where and when a story will take place. You'll be considering 2 factors: the time period, such as the Victorian Era or the Dark Ages, and the location, Britain, India, Nigeria, etc.

In addition, you'll want to consider that if you're writing genres with specific time frames, like medieval, the setting will typically be in the past, such as the Dark Ages. However, this is more a recommendation than a requirement.

Step 4: Create a Conflict

A conflict is what will drive the story into motion and make characters act. It is a series of events that will make the protagonist act to either overcome it or defeat it in some manner. It also serves to create tension or cause chaos in the story.

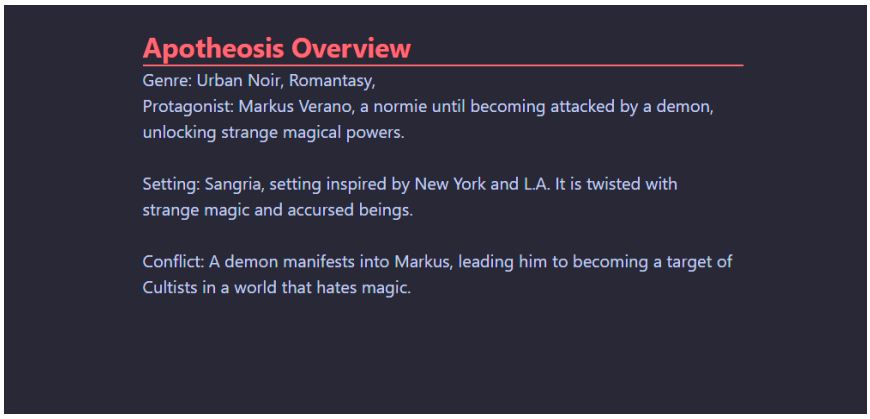

Figure 2. A screenshot from Obsidian.md, an overview that encompasses the conflict, protagonist, and setting. Source. Brian Nguyen

Step 5: Write How the Conflict Begins, Grows, and Ends

How the conflict begins explains how the conflict came into existence.

Its growth should follow how it either gets worse or causes more trouble in the story.

How it ends should be what must be done to cause the conflict to end.

Step 6: Write how the Protagonist is Introduced to the Conflict, How They Handle and Resolve it

Write about how the protagonist and the conflict connect in terms of the story.

The introduction should be how the protagonist first begins to deal with the conflict.

Handling would follow how the protagonist works to deal with it.

Resolution is the protagonist finally solving the problem.

Step 7: Write a One-Sentence Premise

Create a sentence that explains the setting, protagonist, and conflict. It should be able to explain your story.

Figure 3. A screenshot from Obsidian.md, depicting the one-sentence premise of Apotheosis.

Source: Brian Nguyen

Definitions

Protagonist: The main character of the story.

Conflict: tension or a series of events that drives the story forward.

Genre: a category of artistic composition; a set of norms or conventions on a specific form of communication.